

“The story goes that the Japanese emperor was cured of various illnesses by drinking this magical tea. The Korean doctor’s name was Kombu, and so it was called Kombucha (Kombu’s tea),” says 45-year-old Aman Bhatia, Co-founder of Natural Superfoods LLB, which produces the brand Raw Kombucha. Bhatia and his friend Alankar Sharma (both software engineers) set up the company in 2019 when, on returning to India from the US, Bhatia realised there was a market for the product that is considered to have several health benefits. Of course, the Covid-19 pandemic put a stop to their plans. “We properly started marketing only in 2022. Since then, we have seen tremendous growth,” says Bhatia, who sells 20,000 units a month and hopes to increase it to 50,000 units monthly this financial year.

The brand is available in both bottles (₹99 for 250 ml; six flavours) and cans (₹110 for 250 ml; three flavours). The most popular bottled flavours are lemon & ginger and lavender with blue tea, while passion fruit is popular in the can category. Besides being available online on Amazon, JioMart, etc., Bhatia also supplies to various F&B outlets in Delhi NCR, Mumbai, Kolkata, Chandigarh, Jodhpur, Jaipur and Mysuru, amongst others. “There is demand from smaller towns because of international tourists,” he explains, saying that in India, it is gaining traction primarily in metros.

Conventionally, kombucha is made using brewed black or green tea and sucrose. To prepare kombucha, bacteria and yeast in the form of a SCOBY (symbiotic culture of bacteria and yeast)—a biofilm of microorganisms including acetic acid bacteria, lactic acid bacteria and yeasts—are added to the tea and sugar mixture and left to ferment. Different brands ferment for different periods. Bhatia, for instance, ferments in two cycles of 7-10 days each.



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